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ABOUT ALLIANZ

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ALLIANZ CENTER FOR THE FUTURE OF RETIREMENT®

Americans want retirement to feel secure – but many don't know how to get there

Help money last a lifetime by addressing retirement risk

The 2026 Annual Retirement Study from the Allianz Center for the Future of Retirement® reveals growing concern about inflation, market volatility, health care, and the risk of outliving savings. As uncertainty rises, so does the need for guidance. This presents a critical opportunity for financial professionals to help clients turn concern into clarity with strategies that manage risk, adapt to change, and support long-term retirement goals.

"Americans need a partner to help them understand what it takes to retire and develop a strategy that goes beyond accumulating assets. Americans are looking for reassurance that they won't outlive their savings even as market volatility, rising health care costs, and other risks create uncertainty. Durable, reliable income streams for retirement should incorporate risk management solutions to support long-term financial stability. With a documented strategy, Americans will be ready for their financial futures – no matter when they retire or what surprises their financial futures hold."

– Kelly LaVigne, VP of Consumer Insights, Allianz Life

Key insights from the 2026 Annual Retirement Study

The Allianz Center for the Future of Retirement® conducted the 2026 Annual Retirement Study in January 2026 with a nationally representative sample of 1,000 individuals age 25+ with an annual household income of \$50K+/\$75K+ (single/married) OR investable assets of \$150K+. Allianz Center for the Future of Retirement® produces insights and research as a part of Allianz Life Insurance Company of North America..

Allianz Life Insurance Company of North America and Allianz Life Insurance Company of New York are affiliated companies.

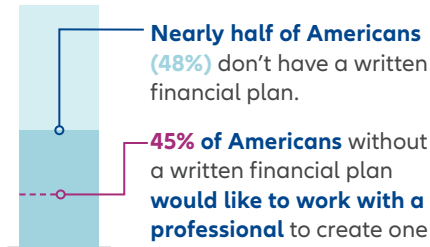
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Retirement accounts are common. Retirement plans are not.

Americans increasingly have no retirement plan on paper



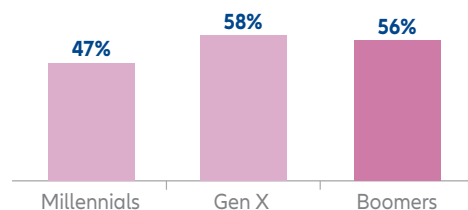
A lack of planning doesn't mean a lack of potential
– it's an open door for guidance. Financial professionals can help close the retirement planning gap by proactively creating structured moments of accountability. A plan creation appointment can help identify personalized strategies that turn scattered savings into a clear, sustainable income path. Starting early makes an impact.



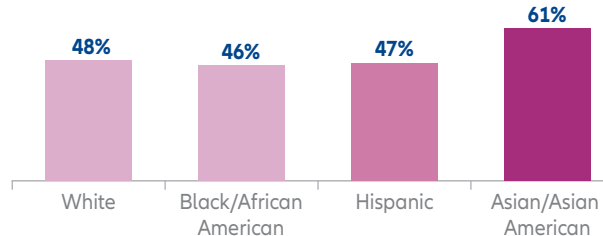
A written strategy, built with the help of a qualified financial professional, can serve as a powerful guidepost, helping clients navigate risk, generate income through tax-efficient withdrawals, and plan for the unexpected. But for many, that roadmap doesn't exist.

Planning gaps at a glance

No written financial plan by generation



No written financial plan by race



What a majority of Americans don't know:



How to start planning for retirement **beyond contributing to a retirement account**



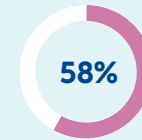
How Social Security **will fit into their retirement plan**



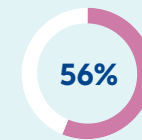
How taxes in retirement **will compare to their current tax situation**



What their health **care costs will be in retirement or how they will pay for them**



Even among those actively contributing to 401(k)s and IRAs, many are unclear on what comes next. It's worrisome that **58% believe that simply having a retirement account** – like a 401(k), 403(b), or IRA – will be enough.



Beyond those contributions, a striking 56% of Americans admit they don't know what else they should be doing to prepare.

By generation

60%	50%	30%
Millennials	Gen X	Boomers

By race

55%	54%
White	Black/African American
61%	56%
Hispanic	Asian/Asian American

Why retirement planning loses out to everyday expenses

Competing financial priorities often push planning to the side

Between everyday expenses and long-term goals, many Americans don't know where to begin. Managing immediate costs while trying to plan ahead can leave people feeling stretched thin and unsure of where to focus and how to prioritize.



69% say saving for retirement is one of their **top financial priorities**

By race

69%	69%	68%	77%
White	Black/African American	Hispanic	Asian/Asian American

By generation

67%	70%	70%
Millennials	Gen X	Boomers



63% say they're juggling so many financial goals, **it's hard to focus or prioritize**

By race

62%	58%	66%	63%
White	Black/African American	Hispanic	Asian/Asian American

By generation

65%	60%	40%
Millennials	Gen X	Boomers



When everything feels like a priority, nothing gets the attention it deserves. Financial professionals can help clients cut through the noise – clarifying goals, creating structure, and building a strategy that balances today's needs with tomorrow's aspirations.

What's getting in the way?

62%

of Americans say **they aren't saving as much** for retirement as they'd like



Day-to-day expenses taking priority



Credit card debt



Mortgage or rent obligations



Health care expenses



Too many unknowns is overwhelming



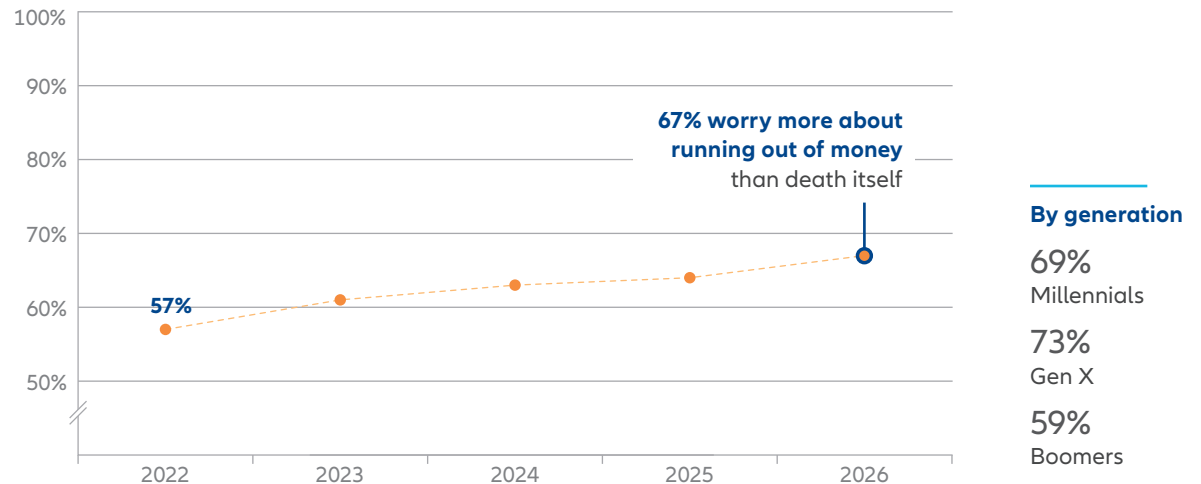
Some Americans think that saving for retirement is the same as planning for retirement. Saving accumulates assets. A retirement plan creates a strategy for converting those accumulated assets into a sustainable, tax-efficient stream of income in retirement. **Financial professionals have a unique opportunity to help clients see this difference, set realistic goals, stay on track, and turn a number into a strategy.**

What Americans fear more than death: living too long on too little



Financial professionals can help ease the worries of outliving retirement savings by offering products that generate dependable income, address inflation, and offer built-in flexibility. The goal? Replace anxiety with a strategy that lasts and adapts. Consider using Health Savings Accounts as a way to accumulate assets and pay for health care out of pocket when possible.

For many Americans, the biggest concern about the future isn't mortality – it's money. Over the past five years, they have grown increasingly worried about making their money last for their entire lifetime. At the same time, concerns about inflation, market volatility, rising health care costs, and the future of Social Security are high.



What's shaking the retirement outlook?



Clients are navigating more uncertainty than ever. Reinforcing products that offer levels of downside protection or guaranteed income, or inflation-adjusted options, can provide greater financial reassurance and long-term resilience. The goal of planning isn't to eliminate the fear, it's to help clients feel more confident about navigating uncertainty.

When asked about their financial future, Americans expressed deep concern across a range of issues that could derail their retirement plans. These concerns underscore the importance of building strategies that not only grow wealth but help protect it over time.

What's fueling this concern?



The rising cost of living will prevent you from enjoying your retirement



You won't be able to afford the **high cost of long-term care**



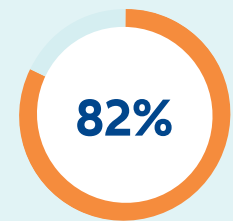
Health care costs will be so high you can't afford the care you need



Social Security will not be available throughout the entirety of your retirement



Medicare will not be available throughout the entirety of your retirement

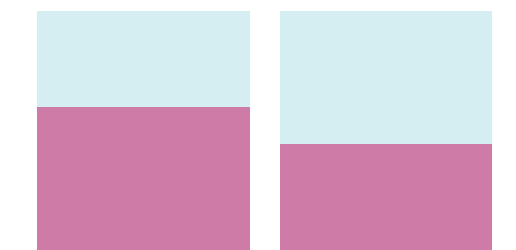


Americans understand how inflation can eat away at purchasing power during retirement. **82% recognize that during a 30-year retirement, it is likely that the cost of goods and services will at least double.**

What Americans expect to spend versus what retirement really costs

Every day is Saturday in retirement. Yet Americans who are still working think they will spend less than retirees say they actually do. This could result in retirees depleting their retirement assets faster than anticipated.

60% of non-retired Americans think they will spend less than 75% of current spending in retirement



45% of retired Americans say they actually spend less than 75% of current spending in retirement

Americans face growing uncertainty about whether their retirement income will go the distance. **When asked about the biggest threats to their financial security in retirement**, these four concerns rose to the top:



Everyday expenses becoming unaffordable



A market drop wiping out retirement savings



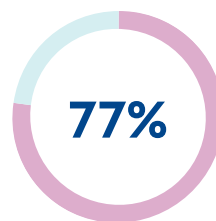
Rising health care costs in retirement



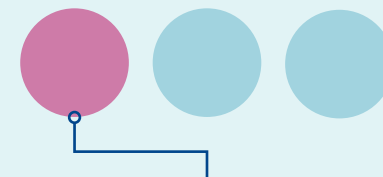
Outliving their money

42% worry they will regret spending too much money early on in retirement

39% of retirees say they are reluctant to spend money in order to preserve their account balance as much as possible



77% say a guaranteed income stream during retirement would decrease their anxiety around spending money in retirement



One in three retirees (32%) say it felt wrong to start drawing down on their assets after accumulating for decades.

Retirees' reluctance to spend

While retirees fear overspending and depleting their assets in retirement, many may limit their spending unreasonably. Retirees have worked hard to accumulate assets, and shifting their mindset into spending mode can be more difficult. A strategy that clearly documents how a client has the freedom to spend and enjoy their retirement can help them spend on what matters to them without fear of regret.

Why did it feel wrong to spend retirement savings?

- Fear of outliving savings
- Uncertainty about future expenses
- Uncertainty about how much they can comfortably spend



A strong retirement strategy starts with understanding what spending will realistically look like after leaving the workforce. Disciplined budgeting is often the path to financial freedom. Financial professionals can help clients align expenses with reliable income – so retirees can spend with confidence. By accounting for risk, inflation, and longevity, financial professionals can help protect income and add flexibility to retirement strategies.

When retirement planning meets reality

Real-world pressures complicate long-term decision making

Even thoughtful financial strategies can feel strained when unexpected pressures enter the picture. Changes in personal circumstances, rising costs, and broader economic uncertainty can all alter assumptions around timing, spending, and long-term security. These realities often add stress, not just to preparing for the future, but to following through on plans already in place.

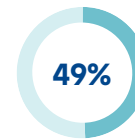


Divorce is rarely part of the plan, but its impact can be lasting. **Financial professionals can help clients build retirement strategies that account for unexpected changes,** including separation, by offering guidance on asset division, retirement account adjustments, and rebuilding a financial foundation after a split.

Gray divorce is rising

While national divorce rates are trending downward overall, separations among Americans aged 65 and older – often called “gray divorce” – **are increasing.**¹ Whether it’s the end of a long-term partnership or a late-in-life fresh start, the financial fallout can be significant.

Shared assets, joint retirement strategies, and fewer working years to rebuild make gray divorce uniquely disruptive. **For many, it’s not just an emotional shift but a major financial detour.**



Among those who’ve gone through a divorce, 49% say it derailed their retirement strategy



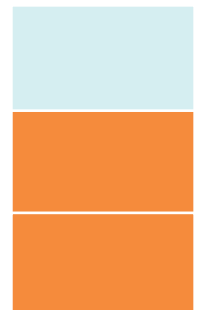
And even for those still married, 59% believe a divorce would seriously impact their ability to retire as planned



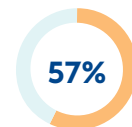
A retirement strategy can address this risk by **diversifying assets across long-term capital gains, regular income, and non-taxable income.** This can offer greater control over when and how taxes are paid in retirement.

Tax questions compound uncertainty

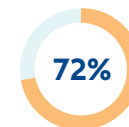
Americans know that taxes pose a risk to their retirement. Yet many do not know what their tax burden will be after leaving the workforce. **The majority of Americans (61%) are not sure how their taxes in retirement will compare to their current tax situation.**



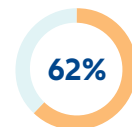
Two in three (66%) worry that taxes will significantly reduce the amount of money they are able to spend in retirement



57% worry that changes in taxes will impact their financial plan



72% believe that effective tax planning is crucial to maximize the funds available during retirement



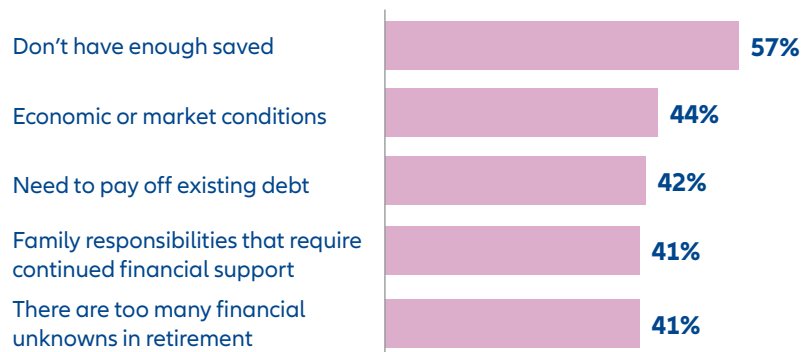
62% consider the tax implications of financial retirement products when evaluating one for their portfolio

Ahead of schedule, behind the curve

While Americans think they will be able to work late into life, many retire earlier than planned. An early retirement poses a unique financial risk by decreasing the number of years to save and increasing the number of years in retirement to fund.



What's holding Americans back from feeling empowered to retire on their own terms

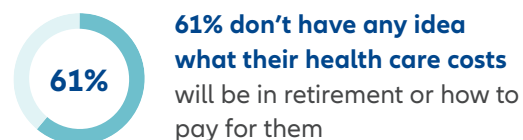


Retirement strategies can include a "forced early retirement" scenario to see what happens if someone stops working earlier than anticipated.

Incorporating additional risk management strategies can help protect against the financial risk of early retirement. These could include reallocating a portion of portfolio assets into products that offer accumulation potential while helping limit downside risk, such as annuities. Financial professionals can help assure their clients that their money will last their lifetime.

Rising health care costs fuel concern, confusion

Health care costs often require a greater part of Americans' budget as they age. Yet many Americans don't know how to plan for it.



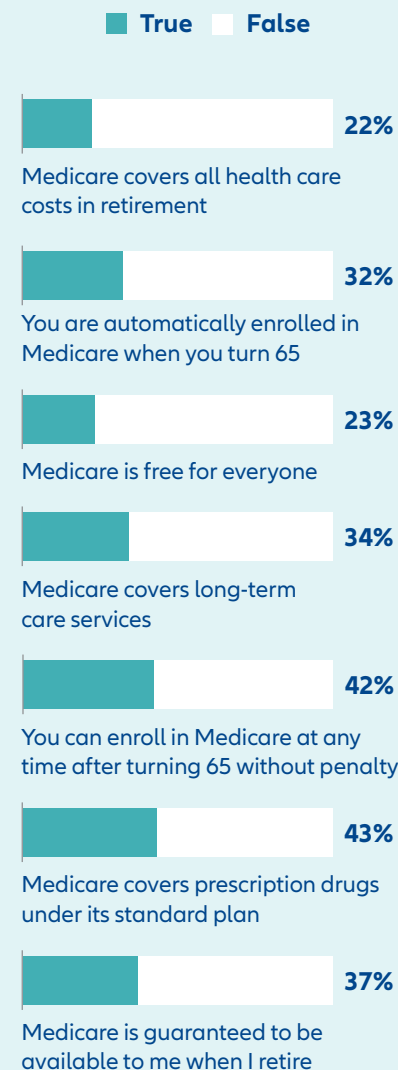
Medicare is a key part of many retirement strategies. It offers Americans aged 65 and older federal health insurance to help pay for some medical costs. But despite its importance, many Americans don't fully understand how it works – or how to make the most of it.

Confusion is only part of the story, and many worry about the future of Medicare. **In 2026, 60% say they worry the program won't last through their full retirement.** That growing lack of trust could drive poor planning decisions if left unaddressed.

Financial professionals are key to helping cut through confusion about how Medicare works and what it can realistically provide. And with trust in the system declining, it's equally important to explore alternative income strategies that can help add security if benefits fall short.

This lack of clarity can lead to costly mistakes in timing, taxation, and expectations.

Would you say the following statements are true or false?



Rethinking what retirement really means

Today's retirees are trading hard stops for gradual shifts

The traditional notion of retirement as a single, final workday is quickly becoming outdated. Instead, Americans are embracing a more flexible, phased approach, gradually easing out of full-time work rather than exiting all at once.

Once they do retire, they're looking to minimize financial stress and make room for new experiences and personal fulfillment. Retirement is no longer the finish line – it's a new beginning.



Retirement today is more than just an end to working years. It's a chance to reshape priorities, pursue passions, and leave a legacy. **Financial professionals can help structure withdrawal strategies and explore retirement income options to achieve these goals.**

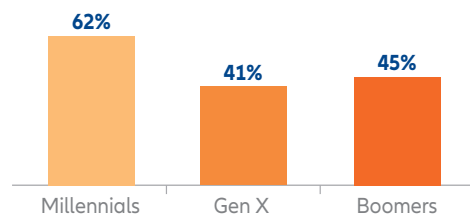


Retirement that gives back

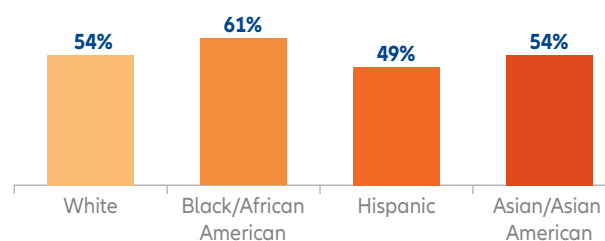
Retirement is also about leaving something meaningful behind. More than half of Americans (56%) say they'd prefer to leave a financial legacy to loved ones or causes they care about, rather than spend down their savings entirely.

Would rather leave a legacy than spend it all:

By generation



By race



Top aspirations for retirement:



Pursue new hobbies



Deepen existing relationships with family and friends



Find new adventures



Find new ways to give back to my community

A smoother ride to retirement

Americans want less turbulence and more income they can count on

Americans have conflicting feelings about participating in the market. They feel like they need to be invested, but worry about market risk. Rather than chasing high returns, many are prioritizing consistency, protection, and predictability.

57% are hesitant to take risks with their investments because they can't afford to lose anything saved

44% believe they need to keep nearly all of their retirement savings in the stock market to avoid falling behind

59% worry that having nearly all of their retirement savings in the stock market makes them vulnerable to losing too much money

Across the board, Americans are anxious about market turbulence. Millennials are particularly reactive to market volatility. With a decades-long horizon to retirement, millennials still have time on their side, and locking in losses can be detrimental to their future wealth.



Three in five (57%) say they feel anxious about their future financial well-being when their retirement accounts suffer a loss due to a market drop

By generation

67%	59%	39%
Millennials	Gen X	Boomers



One in three (34%) say they typically withdraw money from their investments to avoid further losses when the markets experience a significant drop

By generation

46%	30%	8%
Millennials	Gen X	Boomers

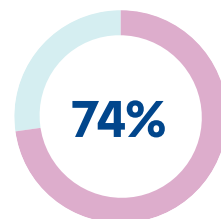


One in two (50%) say they immediately check their retirement accounts to assess the impact when the markets experience a significant drop

By generation

57%	46%	37%
Millennials	Gen X	Boomers

Trading upside for stability



It's no surprise, then, that 74% would rather have financial products that protect against major losses even if it means giving up bigger gains

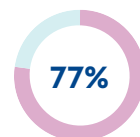
By race

75%	70%	72%	69%
White	Black/African American	Hispanic	Asian/Asian American

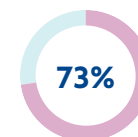
By generation

67%	75%	86%
Millennials	Gen X	Boomers

The demand for guaranteed outcomes is growing



77% say a guaranteed income stream during retirement would decrease their anxiety about spending money in retirement



73% prefer to "set it and forget it" with automatic withdrawals from retirement savings

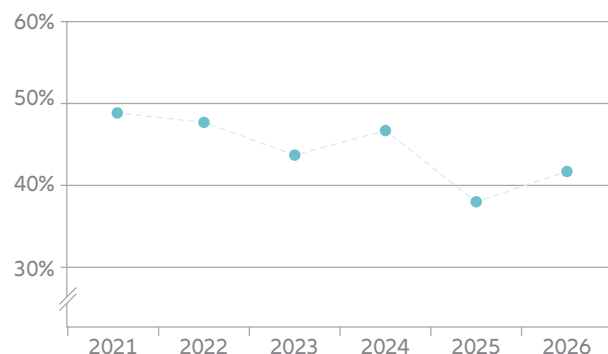


A predetermined market response protocol provides rules for what a client will and will not do when markets decline. This should be created before the next market correction – not during it. **As clients seek more control and confidence in retirement, financial professionals can lead with potential solutions that offer built-in levels of protection, and flexible features – like guaranteed income – that adapt to life's what-ifs.** It's not about giving up growth, it's about building a smoother journey to and through retirement.

Financial professionals: trusted, yet untapped

Americans see the value of financial guidance but many still go it alone

Despite identifying financial professionals as their top source for financial guidance, most Americans aren't currently meeting with one. In fact, the number of people working with a financial professional has declined in recent years even as retirement planning strategies grow more complex.



By race

41%	26%	33%	29%
White	Black/African American	Hispanic	Asian/Asian American

By generation

34%	39%	58%
Millennials	Gen X	Boomers

What tips the scales when choosing a financial professional?

37% want a financial professional who uses financial planning tools to **develop a comprehensive financial strategy**

33% want a financial professional with **a skill set in a particular area**, like retirement or budgeting

41% want recommendations that reflect their actual lives – **not a cookie-cutter financial ideal**

37% want to be known as a person with **values and worries**

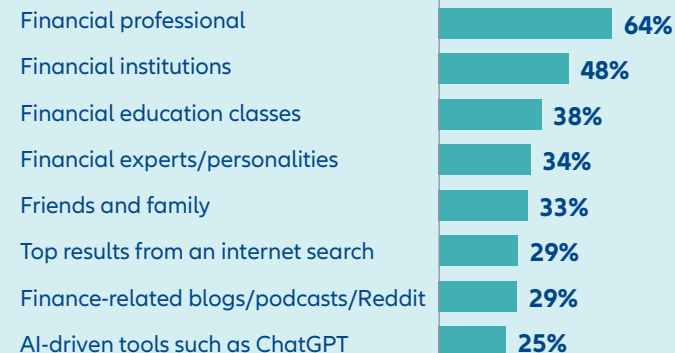
35% value **empathy and understanding** of their financial struggles



The gap between perceived value and actual engagement is a chance to build meaningful connections. Americans seek financial guidance from someone who listens, understands their situation, and offers recommendations that reflect their real life. Financial professionals who meet clients where they are can turn interest into action.

Top sources for financial guidance

(% who ranked each as most helpful)



45% are reluctant to engage with financial professionals for retirement planning due to the fear of being judged

What do clients want most from a financial professional?



Make sure my money lasts as long as I do



Provide a personalized, comprehensive financial plan



Maximize return on investments



Help protect my savings from market loss



Develop a plan to minimize my tax burden

What it all adds up to

From planning gaps to growing legacy goals, the 2026 Annual Retirement Study paints a clear picture: Retirement isn't getting simpler. But with the right strategies, it can be stronger.

Americans are seeking guidance on how to turn uncertainty into action. They want strategies that balance present pressures with future goals. They want protection, predictability, and purpose. Most of all, they want someone in their corner to help them get there.

That's where financial professionals come in – and Allianz is here to help.

Get the insights to guide what's next

Access knowledge and tools to lead the way with confidence

Addressing the complex challenges of retirement strategies requires innovative thinking, grounded in data and insights. The Allianz Center for the Future of Retirement® (part of Allianz) delivers actionable insights backed by 125+ years of experience in risk management and innovation across annuities, life insurance, and ETFs (Allianz Investment Management LLC is the adviser to the AllianzIM ETFs).

Whether you're helping clients navigate guaranteed income, market volatility, or legacy planning strategies, the Center's **signature research and specialized analysis can help you stay ahead of what's next in retirement.**



→ EXPLORE THE LATEST INSIGHTS AT
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